



Identifying when to use an article

If a singular noun can be counted, this noun will require an article—definite or indefinite. For example, “I saw elephant today” doesn’t make sense. Some nouns, such as *happiness*, *information*, and *bread*, do not have a plural form, and therefore cannot be counted. These nouns can be used without an article (zero article) or with the definite article. They never take the indefinite article.

elephant

This noun can be counted, so the definite or indefinite article can be used.

one elephant
two elephants

the elephant

an elephant

bread

This noun cannot be counted.

one bread
two breads

The definite article can be used for a specific piece of bread.

the bread

The zero article is used for the concept of bread in general.

bread

friend, **an** elephant, took ostrich at flying school.

The zero article

Some words, such as *school*, *life*, and *home*, take the definite article when a particular one is being referred to, and the indefinite article when one of several is being described. When these words are used to describe a general concept, such as being at school, the article is removed. This absence of an article is known as the zero article.

at flying school

This describes school as a concept—a place where a person goes to learn something—so the zero article (no article) is used.

at **the** flying school next to the zoo

This describes a particular school—the one next to the zoo—so *the* is required.



- Many **geographical areas** and features, including **rivers**, **deserts**, and **oceans**, use the **definite article**: for example, the North Pole, the Pacific Ocean, or the Rocky Mountains.

- If an **article** is at the beginning of the **title** of a work, such as *The Secret Garden*, it should start with a **capital letter**.

- Unique things**, such as **the sun**, always take *the*.

- Watch out for words that begin with a **vowel** that **sounds like a consonant**, such as *university*. These take the indefinite article *a*, rather than *an*.